DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Is the World Getting Better or Worse?

Daat Tevunot, Summary

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** Summary of Sections 3-5 (the English edition's short summaries, pages 654-657) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 20 April 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap of Sections 1 and 2

The class continued the summaries at the back of the English edition. Section 1: the purpose of life is for God to bestow good, through humans perfecting themselves. Section 2: this happens through revealing His oneness.

The Rabbi explained why oneness is the one attribute that can be revealed. Every attribute of God, His hesed, His gevurah, is infinite; no human can grasp it. We can understand Him only negatively, through His oneness. We see things in the world that suggest other powers, and we deny them and resist those temptations, showing that there is nothing but Him. Adam saw that the tree was good to look at and tasty, but God had said no. Eating it amounted to saying "I stand to gain by going against God's will." "If you truly believe there's one force in the world, you'll never sin."

Section 3: concealment, and the light within it

During the first phase, God conceals His presence and man is free to choose good or evil. Yet God is still the source of everything, since nothing exists without His emanation, though it is only a faint trace of His true power. "Within the hester there has to be light."

And there is more. Because this phase is temporary and leads to the inevitable revelation of His oneness, God also sends a powerful emanation of His perfection that acts in a hidden way, guiding the world towards perfection through the events of history. The Ramhal calls this the tikkun hakelali, the overall rectification. A participant asked whether this is the "override button". No, said the Rabbi, that is the separate question of the two modes of rule. Here we mean that within the hester there is (a) the light that sustains existence and (b) the light guiding the world to its end. By 6,000 the world will reach its final tikkun even if we do not do our part, though if we do, it comes earlier.

Asked whether these are two emanations or one, the Rabbi said the Ramhal does not discuss it, but it makes most sense that it is one light with a double function.

By concealing His presence, God brings about a system of forces that reacts to man's good and bad deeds, bringing light or darkness, while the emanation of perfection works in the

background, whether man deserves it or not. At the redemption this hidden plan will be revealed and we will see everything was for the good. Even then, the Rabbi stressed, no human will understand God Himself.

Getting better, not heading for collapse

A participant asked whether "guiding" means things are improving, or whether the world might destroy itself until a sudden end at 6,000. The Rabbi was clear: "It's the former, for sure." There are ups and downs, but the overarching light ensures that the world comes to perfection.

He gave examples of how, in his view, the world is returning towards the state of Bereshit:

- The curse of Havah was pain in childbirth. Childbirth is still painful, but there is no comparison with the past, when death in childbirth was far more common; today there are epidurals and caesareans.
- The curse of Adam was to eat bread by the sweat of his brow. Most of us no longer sweat physically for our living, though we have other kinds of stress. More and more is being done for us.
- At Bavel, God confused the languages. Today there is globalisation and instant translation; there is almost no one you cannot speak to.
- In one opinion in the Gemara, Adam was created with two faces, male and female together. For thousands of years men have dominated; the move to equality between men and women, which the Rabbi called a strong Torah value, is a return to that original state.

Section 4: body and soul

God created man from two entities: a coarse body, the source of his imperfections, and a pure soul whose task is to purify the body. In this world the soul's power is reduced, like a dimmed light, so that it is on equal footing with the body and does not simply overpower it.

Everything elevated comes from revelation, heara; everything coarse comes from concealment, hester. The soul is one and permeates the whole body, like yihud; the body has many parts, like hester, which is many powers. When the soul prevails, more light enters; when the body prevails, more darkness. Our body and soul are a microcosm of the universe, and just as revelation will finally overcome concealment, the soul will rectify the body.

The epochs: during the 6,000 years the body dominates unless you fight it. From 6,000 to 7,000 the soul rules, but the body is still there as a guest, like Moshe on the mountain for forty days without food or drink. After that the body is renewed and wholly submissive; it will not need to eat or drink.

Why have a body at all then? A participant answered: the body did the work, so it should share the reward. The Rabbi agreed, noting that the Rambam speaks of the world to come as soul alone while most disagreed. In his view the Rambam and the Ramhal are close: even for the Ramhal it is a renewed body, not the body we know, and the soul is wholly in control.

Section 5 begins: the nature of evil

Since man's main task in the 6,000 years is to remove evil, we must understand what evil is. Evil is a totally new phenomenon, created to test man, temporary and held within limits. If God is perfect good, how can anything imperfect come from Him?

A participant argued that God made man exactly as He wanted, so man is perfect even though he can sin. The Rabbi disagreed firmly: "perfect can't create imperfection" on its own, and the very ability to do bad is itself an imperfection. "Even if I behave perfectly, if I have the ability to do something bad, I'm still imperfect." That is the question of Section 5, to be finished on Monday.

Summary

- Section 3: within the concealment there is light that sustains the world, and a hidden light, the tikkun hakelali, guiding history to perfection.
- The Rabbi holds that the world is gradually improving, and sees modern developments as a return towards the state before the curses of Bereshit.
- Section 4: body and soul mirror concealment and revelation; the soul is dimmed now and will rule in the future.
- The future body shares in the reward because it shared in the work.
- Section 5: evil is new, temporary and limited; even the ability to do bad is an imperfection.

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